

Post-incident review PIR-2025-003

Customer Portal: intermittent timeouts

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 16 February 2025, Customer Portal experienced intermittent timeouts in production (AU Southeast) for about 160 minutes. A latency threshold alert fired for the service's main endpoint. Investigation found that a null reference in the new release crashed workers on a rare input.

Impact

Users of Customer Portal saw intermittent timeouts for about 160 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:19 First signal received.
- 09:36 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:50 Likely cause identified.
- 10:21 Mitigation applied.
- 10:37 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a null reference in the new release crashed workers on a rare input.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Add a pre-deployment check that validates the setting against the production baseline.